

Common Latin Jazz Chord Progressions

Harmonic templates used across salsa, Afro-Cuban jazz, bossa nova, and tango

Each progression is shown in a common key with scale recommendations, then transposed to all 12 keys. Use these as vamp tracks for practicing your scales and riffs.

1. The Dorian Vamp (i7 - IV7)

Style: Salsa, Latin rock, cha-cha | Think: Oye Como Va, Evil Ways, Black Magic Woman

Bar	Chord	Scale	Notes
1-2	Am7	A Dorian: A B C D E F# G	Home base — emphasize F# (natural 6th)
3-4	D9	D Mixolydian: D E F# G A B C	Same notes as A Dorian — one scale fits all

Why it works: Am7 and D9 share the same notes (A Dorian = D Mixolydian). You can solo with one scale over the entire vamp. This is the simplest latin jazz progression and the best place to start.

Also try: A minor pentatonic, A blues scale, or switch between Dorian and pentatonic.

In all 12 keys:

Key	i7	IV7	Dorian Scale
A	Am7	D9	A B C D E F# G
Bb	Bbm7	Eb9	Bb C Db Eb F G Ab
B	Bm7	E9	B C# D E F# G# A
C	Cm7	F9	C D Eb F G A Bb
C#	C#m7	F#9	C# D# E F# G# A# B
D	Dm7	G9	D E F G A B C
Eb	Ebm7	Ab9	Eb F Gb Ab Bb C Db
E	Em7	A9	E F# G A B C# D
F	Fm7	Bb9	F G Ab Bb C D Eb
F#	F#m7	B9	F# G# A B C# D# E
G	Gm7	C9	G A Bb C D E F
Ab	Abm7	Db9	Ab Bb Cb Db Eb F Gb

2. The Minor ii-V-i

Style: The backbone of ALL latin jazz harmony | Think: Besame Mucho, Tin Tin Deo, Blue Bossa

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale	Tension Level
1-2	Dm7(b5)	ii	D Locrian #2: D E F G Ab Bb C	Low
3-4	G7(b9)	V	G Spanish/Jewish: G Ab B C D Eb F	Medium-High
5-8	Cm6	i	C Harmonic Minor: C D Eb F G Ab B	Resolution

Dominant substitutions (try these on the V chord for different flavors):

V Chord Scale	Sound	When to Use
G Spanish/Jewish	Classic latin, Afro-Cuban	Default choice — always works
G Altered (Dim WT)	Maximum tension, modern jazz	When you want to push outside

V Chord Scale	Sound	When to Use
G Diminished (H-W)	Angular, symmetric	Over G7b9 for a jazzy edge
G Bebop Dominant	Smooth eighth-note lines	For flowing bebop-style lines
G Whole Tone	Floating, dreamy	Over G7#5 voicings

In all 12 minor keys:

Key	ii (half-dim)	V7(b9)	i
Cm	Dm7(b5)	G7(b9)	Cm
C#m	D#m7(b5)	G#7(b9)	C#m
Dm	Em7(b5)	A7(b9)	Dm
Ebm	Fm7(b5)	Bb7(b9)	Ebm
Em	F#m7(b5)	B7(b9)	Em
Fm	Gm7(b5)	C7(b9)	Fm
F#m	G#m7(b5)	C#7(b9)	F#m
Gm	Am7(b5)	D7(b9)	Gm
Abm	Bbm7(b5)	Eb7(b9)	Abm
Am	Bm7(b5)	E7(b9)	Am
Bbm	Cm7(b5)	F7(b9)	Bbm
Bm	C#m7(b5)	F#7(b9)	Bm

3. The Major ii-V-I

Style: Bossa nova, Latin jazz standards | Think: Desafinado, Girl from Ipanema, Corcovado

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale
1-2	Dm7	ii	D Dorian: D E F G A B C
3-4	G7	V	G Mixolydian: G A B C D E F (or Bebop Dom)
5-8	Cmaj7	I	C Major: C D E F G A B (or C Lydian)

In all 12 major keys:

Key	ii	V7	I
C	Dm7	G7	Cmaj7
Db	Ebm7	Ab7	Dbmaj7
D	Em7	A7	Dmaj7
Eb	Fm7	Bb7	Ebmaj7
E	F#m7	B7	Emaj7
F	Gm7	C7	Fmaj7
F#	G#m7	C#7	F#maj7
G	Am7	D7	Gmaj7
Ab	Bbm7	Eb7	Abmaj7
A	Bm7	E7	Amaj7
Bb	Cm7	F7	Bbmaj7
B	C#m7	F#7	Bmaj7

4. Cycle of Dominants

Style: Swing/latin bridge sections | Think: Caravan bridge, Autumn Leaves, rhythm changes bridge

Bar	Chord	Resolves to	Scale
1-2	F7	Bb7	F Mixolydian (or Bebop Dominant)
3-4	Bb7	Eb7	Bb Mixolydian
5-6	Eb7	Abmaj7	Eb Mixolydian
7-8	Abmaj7	(home)	Ab Major or Ab Lydian

Pattern: Each dominant 7th resolves down a perfect 5th to the next. Use Mixolydian or Bebop Dominant on each chord. This pattern appears in bridges of many standards.

Advanced: Try Spanish/Jewish on each dominant for a latin flavor, or Altered for maximum tension.

5. Phrygian Cadence (bII - V7(b9) - i)

Style: Tango, flamenco-jazz, dramatic latin | Think: Piazzolla, Caravan intro, Spanish-tinged jazz

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale
1-2	Dbmaj7	bII	Db Lydian: Db Eb F G Ab Bb C
3-4	G7(b9)	V	G Spanish/Jewish: G Ab B C D Eb F
5-8	Cm	i	C Harmonic Minor: C D Eb F G Ab B

The tango signature: The bII chord (a half step above the tonic) slides down to the V7(b9), then resolves to i. The augmented 2nd interval in the Spanish scale IS the sound of tango.

In all 12 minor keys:

i	bII	V7(b9)	i
Cm	Dbmaj7	G7(b9)	Cm
C#m	Dmaj7	G#7(b9)	C#m
Dm	Ebmaj7	A7(b9)	Dm
Ebm	Emaj7 (Fbmaj7)	Bb7(b9)	Ebm
Em	Fmaj7	B7(b9)	Em
Fm	Gbmaj7	C7(b9)	Fm
F#m	Gmaj7	C#7(b9)	F#m
Gm	Abmaj7	D7(b9)	Gm
Abm	Amaj7 (Bbbmaj7)	Eb7(b9)	Abm
Am	Bbmaj7	E7(b9)	Am
Bbm	Cbmaj7 (Bmaj7)	F7(b9)	Bbm
Bm	Cmaj7	F#7(b9)	Bm

6. bVI - V7(b9) - i (Dramatic Minor Cadence)

Style: Bolero, tango, dramatic ballads | Think: Besame Mucho, Obsesion

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale
1-2	Abmaj7	bVI	Ab Major: Ab Bb C Db Eb F G
3-4	G7(b9)	V	G Spanish/Jewish: G Ab B C D Eb F
5-8	Cm	i	C Harmonic Minor: C D Eb F G Ab B

This **cadence** is extremely common in bolero and tango. The bVI chord shares two notes with the i chord (Ab and C in Cm), creating a smooth voice-leading descent: Ab -> G -> G (bVI root drops to V root to resolve).

In all 12 keys:

i	bVI	V7(b9)
Cm	Abmaj7	G7(b9)
Dm	Bbmaj7	A7(b9)
Em	Cmaj7	B7(b9)
Fm	Dbmaj7	C7(b9)
Gm	Ebmaj7	D7(b9)
Am	Fmaj7	E7(b9)
Bbm	Gbmaj7	F7(b9)
Bm	Gmaj7	F#7(b9)

7. Salsa Montuno Vamp (I - IV - V - IV)

Style: Salsa, son montuno, descarga | The dance floor groove

Bar	Chord	Scale
1	C	C Major: C D E F G A B
2	F	F Major (or F Lydian)
3	G7	G Mixolydian: G A B C D E F
4	F	F Major

Simplicity is power: This I-IV-V-IV loop drives hundreds of salsa tunes. Use C major pentatonic over the whole thing. Add blues notes for flavor. Focus on RHYTHM, not note complexity.

8. Guajira (Cuban 6/8-3/4 Hemiola)

Style: Traditional Cuban, guajira-son | Think: Guantanamera, Paquito D'Rivera's guajiras, Bebo Valdes

The signature sound: The guajira alternates between **6/8** and **3/4** feel — the same 6 eighth notes can be grouped as 2 groups of 3 (compound duple) or 3 groups of 2 (simple triple). This creates a rolling, rural, lyrical feel unlike anything else in latin music.

Classic Guajira Form (16 bars, alternating major/relative minor):

Bars	Chord	Feel	Scale
1-2	C	I (major, 6/8)	C Major Pentatonic: C D E G A
3-4	G7	V	G Mixolydian: G A B C D E F
5-6	C	I	C Major: C D E F G A B
7-8	G7	V	G Mixolydian
9-10	Am	vi (shift to minor)	A Natural Minor: A B C D E F G
11-12	E7	V/vi	E Spanish/Jewish: E F G# A B C D
13-14	Am / Dm	vi / ii	A Aeolian / D Dorian
15-16	G7 / C	V / I (back home)	G Mixolydian / C Major

Scale strategy: Keep it simple and lyrical. Use major pentatonic in the major sections, natural minor (Aeolian) in the minor sections. The E7 to Am is the only dramatic moment — use E Spanish/Jewish here for the traditional Cuban flavor.

The 6/8 vs 3/4 Hemiola:

Feel	Grouping	Accent Pattern	Character
6/8	Two groups of 3: (1-2-3)(4-5-6)	> . . > . .	Flowing, rolling, pastoral
3/4	Three groups of 2: (1-2)(3-4)(5-6)	> . > . > .	March-like, lilting, Spanish
Combined	Alternate between them	Shifting accents	THE guajira sound

Practice tip: Play a C major scale for 6 beats. First pass in 6/8 (accent beats 1 and 4). Second pass in 3/4 (accent beats 1, 3, and 5). Once you can switch smoothly, you've got the guajira feel.

Simplified Guajira Vamp (for practice):

Bars	Chord	Scale
1-4	C	C Major Pentatonic
5-8	Am	A Natural Minor
9-12	Dm	D Dorian: D E F G A B C
13-16	G7 / C	G Mixolydian resolving to C Major

In all 12 keys (simplified I - V7 - vi - V/vi pattern):

Major Key	I	V7	vi	V7/vi
C	C	G7	Am	E7
Db	Db	Ab7	Bbm	F7
D	D	A7	Bm	F#7
Eb	Eb	Bb7	Cm	G7
E	E	B7	C#m	G#7
F	F	C7	Dm	A7
F#	F#	C#7	D#m	A#7
G	G	D7	Em	B7
Ab	Ab	Eb7	Fm	C7
A	A	E7	F#m	C#7
Bb	Bb	F7	Gm	D7
B	B	F#7	G#m	D#7

Why this matters: The guajira is the countryside soul of Cuban music — simpler and more melodic than the urban son montuno. Learning it gives you access to the lyrical, singable side of latin jazz. 'Guantanamera' is the most famous example — if you can play over its changes, you understand the guajira.

9. Minor Descending Cycle (i - iv - VII - III - VI - ii - V - i)

Style: Tango nuevo, sophisticated jazz | Think: Oblivion (Piazzolla), Autumn Leaves

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale
1-2	Cm	i	C Dorian (or Melodic Minor)
3-4	Fm7	iv	F Dorian: F G Ab Bb C D Eb
5-6	Bb7	VII	Bb Mixolydian: Bb C D Eb F G Ab
7-8	Ebmaj7	III	Eb Major: Eb F G Ab Bb C D
9-10	Abmaj7	VI	Ab Lydian: Ab Bb C D Eb F G
11-12	Dm7(b5)	ii	D Locrian #2: D E F G Ab Bb C

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale
13-14	G7(b9)	V	G Spanish/Jewish: G Ab B C D Eb F
15-16	Cm	i	C Harmonic Minor: C D Eb F G Ab B

The complete minor key journey: This cycle touches every diatonic chord in C minor. It descends by 4ths (C-F-Bb-Eb-Ab-D-G-C). This is the progression in Piazzolla's Oblivion and many jazz standards.

Scale strategy: Use Dorian/Melodic Minor on i, Dorian on iv, Mixolydian on VII and III area, Locrian #2 on ii, Spanish/Jewish on V, Harmonic Minor for final resolution.

10. Static Dominant Vamp

Style: Afro-Cuban, descarga, guaguanco | Think: Manteca A section, rumba jams

Bar	Chord	Scale Options
1-8+	Bb7 (static, no resolution)	Bb Mixolydian — safe, consonant Bb Lydian Dominant — bright #4 color Bb Blues — earthy, soulful Bb Bebop Dominant — smooth 8th-note lines

When the dominant doesn't resolve: Use Lydian Dominant instead of Mixolydian. The #4 prevents the chord from wanting to resolve, matching the static harmony. This is common in Afro-Cuban vamps where a dominant chord just grooves indefinitely.

11. Tritone Substitution Turnaround

Style: Modern bossa, sophisticated latin jazz | Think: Desafinado, jobim ballads

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale
1	Cmaj7	I	C Major
2	Db7(#11)	subV/I (tritone sub of G7)	Db Lydian Dominant: Db Eb F G Ab Bb Cb
3	Cmaj7	I	C Lydian: C D E F# G A B
4	B7(#11)	subV/ii (tritone sub of F7)	B Lydian Dominant: B C# D# E# F# G# A

Tritone substitutions replace a V7 chord with a dominant 7th a tritone away (e.g., Db7 replaces G7). The Lydian Dominant scale is THE scale for these chords. This is the sound of sophisticated bossa nova harmony (Jobim used this constantly).

Rule of thumb: See a dominant 7th with a #11 or b5? Use Lydian Dominant every time.

12. Latin Minor Blues (12-bar)

Style: Latin blues, Afro-Cuban blues | Think: Senor Blues, Blue Monk (latin arrangement)

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale
1-4	Cm7	i	C Dorian, C Minor Pentatonic, C Blues
5-6	Fm7	iv	F Dorian: F G Ab Bb C D Eb
7-8	Cm7	i	C Dorian or C Blues
9	Dm7(b5)	ii	D Locrian #2: D E F G Ab Bb C
10	G7(b9)	V	G Spanish/Jewish or G Altered
11-12	Cm7	i	C Minor Pentatonic (turnaround)

The minor blues is a 12-bar form that bridges blues and jazz. You can play minor pentatonic or blues scale over the entire form, then get more specific with Dorian on the i, Spanish/Jewish on the V. Latin feel comes from the rhythm, not the harmony.

13. Piazzolla Tango Sequence (chromatic bass descent)

Style: *Tango nuevo* | Think: *Libertango*, *Adios Nonino*, *Buenos Aires Hora Cero*

Bar	Chord (over bass)	Bass Note	Scale
1	Am	A	A Harmonic Minor
2	Am/G#	G# (descending)	A Harmonic Minor (G# is the leading tone)
3	Am/G	G natural	A Dorian (G natural implies natural 7th descent)
4	Am/F#	F#	D Lydian Dominant or passing diminished
5	Dm/F	F	D Dorian or D Harmonic Minor
6	E7	E	E Spanish/Jewish: E F G# A B C D
7-8	Am	A	A Harmonic Minor (resolution)

The **chromatic descending bass line** (A - G# - G - F# - F - E) is the DNA of tango nuevo. While the bass descends chromatically, the upper harmony shifts between harmonic minor, dorian, and passing diminished sounds. This creates the dramatic, cinematic quality of Piazzolla.

Practice tip: Play A harmonic minor over the first 2 bars, then let your ear guide you through the chromatic descent. The E7 at the end is pure Spanish/Jewish territory.

Quick Reference: All 13 Progressions

#	Progression	Style	Key Scale(s)
1	i7 - IV7 (Dorian Vamp)	Salsa, cha-cha	Dorian, Minor Pentatonic
2	ii(b5) - V7(b9) - i (Minor ii-V-i)	All latin jazz	Locrian #2, Spanish/Jewish, Harm Minor
3	ii - V7 - I (Major ii-V-I)	Bossa nova	Dorian, Mixolydian, Major
4	V7/ii - V7/V - V7 - I (Cycle of Doms)	Swing/latin bridges	Mixolydian on each
5	bII - V7(b9) - i (Phrygian Cadence)	Tango, flamenco	Lydian, Spanish/Jewish, Harm Minor
6	bVI - V7(b9) - i	Bolero, tango	Major, Spanish/Jewish, Harm Minor
7	I - IV - V - IV (Montuno Vamp)	Salsa, son	Major Pentatonic
8	Guajira (6/8-3/4 hemiola, I-V-vi-E7)	Cuban countryside	Major Pentatonic, Natural Minor, Spanish
9	i-iv-VII-III-VI-ii-V-i (Minor Cycle)	Tango nuevo, jazz	Dorian, Mixolydian, Spanish
10	Static V7 (Dominant Vamp)	Afro-Cuban, descarga	Lydian Dominant, Mixolydian
11	I - subV - I (Tritone Sub)	Modern bossa	Lydian Dominant
12	12-bar Minor Blues	Latin blues	Blues, Dorian, Spanish
13	Chromatic Bass Descent	Tango nuevo	Harmonic Minor, Spanish